as a stray departure with no seeming link at all with the main story—is significant. Six short verses speak of Ashoka's end before the narrative resumes its history of Buddhism in Sri Lanka. The *Mahavamsa* is known to have derived a great deal from the *Dipavamsa* but the latter text is silent about Ashoka's last years. The only possible conclusion is that the brief account in the former is some version of the popular view about Ashoka's last years in this part of South Asia in the fifth century.

In terms of the internal logic of the *Mahavamsa*, it is not fortuitous that the account of Ashoka's later years begins in the eighteenth year of his rule, with a sapling of the Bodhi tree being brought to Sri Lanka: the chapter preceding the passage quoted primarily concerns itself with 'The coming of the Bodhi-tree' to Sri Lanka,[3] carried there from the eastern Indian port of Tamralipti by Ashoka's daughter Sanghamitra. She had become a nun and appears as the tree's primary guardian on this voyage, terrifying into submission certain serpents ('Nagas') who seemed interested in acquiring it. The sacred sapling was planted in the Mahameghavanarama, where 'the king of trees, the great Bodhi-tree, lasted a long time on the island of Lanka.'[4] This section of the text is followed almost immediately by six verses which recount the manner in which the 'great Bodhi-tree' of Mahabodhi came to be destroyed, the juxtaposition serving the purpose of underlining the different destinies of the two trees, the original in the north and its offshoot on the island. Ashoka's end, recounted immediately after the fate of the Bodhi tree, seems to indicate that even while the chronology of his twilight regnal years is not a calendar concocted by this chronicle, positioning Ashoka's death after elaborating in detail on the fate of the Bodhi tree in Sri Lanka is not incidental but deliberate. The underlying logic seems to be to decry the fate of the faith in the land of its origin while hailing its reception and long life in Lanka.

The contrast in the actions of the two women associated with Ashoka also links with the differing histories of Buddhism in the mainland and the